INDIA@PARIS 2024

DOUBLE DESIRE

NEERAJ CHOPRA, 26

Sport: ***JAVELIN THROW***

Achievements: **Olympic champion, World Champion, Asian Games gold medalist**

How he qualified: **With an 88.77 metre effort in the 2023 World Athletics men's javelin throw final qualification round (85.5 metres is the qualification mark)**



Winning has become such second nature to Neeraj Chopra since Tokyo 2020 that when one talks of a sure-shot medal in Paris, the question asked is, "*Neeraj nahin, toh kaun* (If not Neeraj, then who)?" Indeed, it's a testament to his dominance in the sport that the medal's hue under discussion is always yellow. "The target is to defend my title," Chopra had said during a media interaction in April. "Whatever I can do to make that happen, I am concentrating on it."

If you've followed Chopra's exploits with the javelin, you know he doesn't follow its trajectory to know he's put in a winning throw. Like many supreme athletes, Neeraj just knows it it. A brisk run with the spear, his powerful right arm stretched to its fullest, the emphatic throw, the swift recovery from a choreographed fall, the turn to the audience, a scream with both his hands in the air. The seconds-long routine, much like Sachin's immaculate cover drive, never gets old.

India has seen its share of great sports stars, and the attributes that unite them are consistency and hunger. Luckily for us, Chopra isn't the